ELIMINATION PLAYS

ABOUT THE DEALS

Feel free to disagree with the bidding; remember that it is only there so as to get to a contract appropriate for some particular elimination play. In fact, the bidding is irrelevant except in Deals where the opponent's bids may influence your actions.

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. This is to get you started thinking about how you would play the hand.

There are four or five stages shown for each Deal.

You are always going to be the Declarer, playing in the South position.

ELIMINATION PLAYS SUMMARY

There are a lot of card combinations in Bridge in which you will be better off if the opponents make the first play in a suit than you would be if you must play it first. Here are three examples.

♦ K 10 3	♦ J 7 3	♦ K 10 3
♦ A J 7	♦ Q 5 2	♦ A 9 7

The first is the frequently occurring two-way finesse. If you play this yourself you have to guess which defender holds the Queen. If the defenders start the suit you automatically win all three tricks.

In the second example you'd like to win one trick, and it will be hard to do if you must start the suit. Perhaps one defender holds both the high honors and you can guess which one and lead through him. Or perhaps someone has a doubleton honor that you can deduce. But if the defenders break the suit you just play second-hand-low and can't miss winning one trick.

With the third example you have almost no chance of three tricks if you start. If they start the suit you play second-hand-low and the next defender must play an honor. You win and then finesse the other defender for the other honor, winning all three tricks when their two honors are divided.

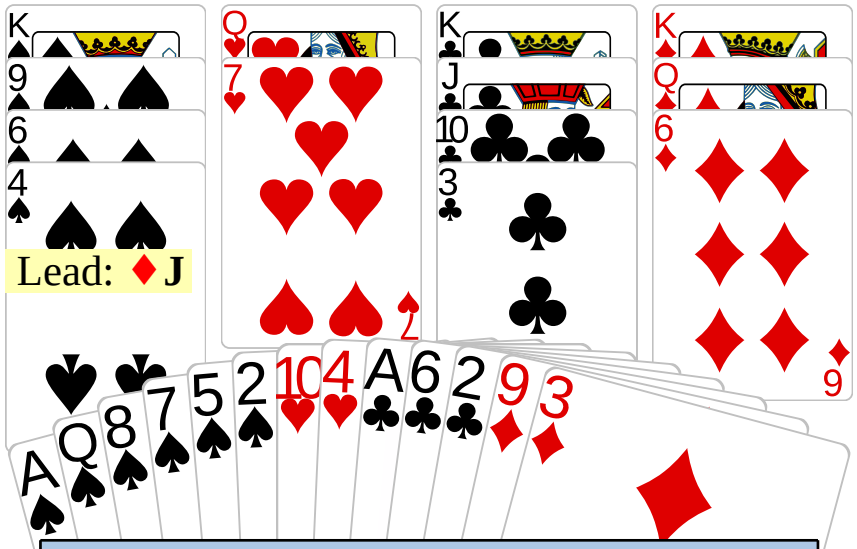
These are only three of many combinations that will benefit you if you can force the defenders to start the suit.
And that is what Elimination plays do; force the defenders to play a particular suit for you.

It works like this. You **strip** the defenders of all their "safe" exit suits, then you **throw-in** one of the defenders. If he has no safe exit, he will have to play a suit that will benefit you, perhaps one of the combinations above.

You will find that most elimination plays occur in suit contracts. This is because you can often pull all the defender's trumps while retaining at least one in both your hand and dummy. Then when the throw-in occurs the defense cannot play a suit of which you and dummy are both void because of the threat of a ruff and sluff.

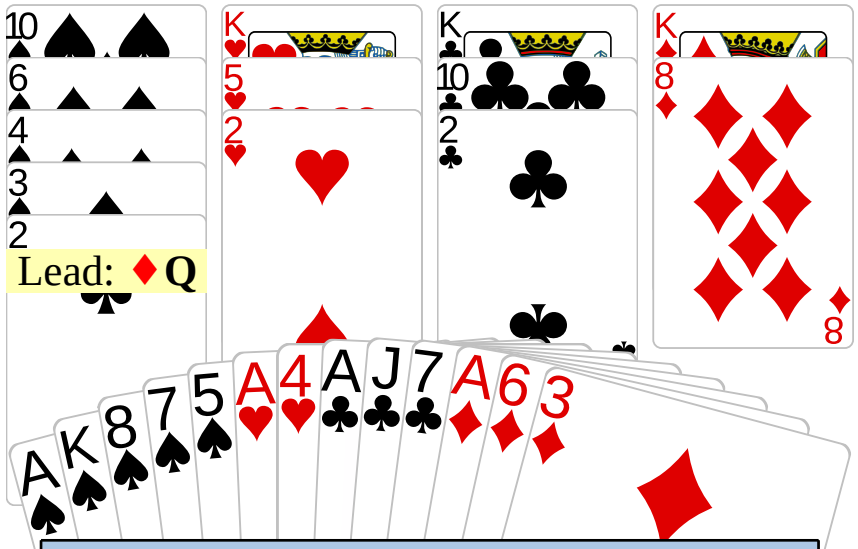
25 examples are probably worth more than 1000 words.

Deal 1 Ctr: **4♠** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 2 Ctr: **6♠** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 3 Ctr: **4♥** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 4 Ctr: **6♦** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Board: 1
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: North
Lead: ♦J

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 6♠
Declarer: East
Lead: ♦Q

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: South
Lead: ♠K

Board: 4
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 6♦
Declarer: West
Lead: ♠Q

Board 1
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ A Q 8 7 5 2 ♥ 10 4 ♦ 9 3 ♣ A 6 2	
♠ 10 ♥ K J 8 3 2 ♦ A 5 4 2 ♣ 9 7 4		♠ J 3 ♥ A 9 6 5 ♦ J 10 8 7 ♣ Q 8 5
	♠ K 9 6 4 ♥ Q 7 ♦ K Q 6 ♣ K J 10 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♣
Pass	1♠	Pass	2♠
Pass	4♠		
All Pass			

4♠ by North
Lead: ♦J

North is to play 4♠. East leads the ♦J, covered by the ♦Q and ♦A. West returns a ♦ to the ♦K.

You still have two losers in the ♥ suit, so the question is which way you plan to finesse the ♣s. And of course the answer is that you don't plan to finesse them at all!

Pull trumps with the ♠A, then ♠K. Next ruff dummy's last ♦.

You exit with a ♥. The defenders win this and take another ♥ trick, leaving this position.

They must now break the ♣ suit for you or give you a ruff-sluff. Of course you would ruff in dummy and discard a ♣ from the 3-card holding in your hand.

If West is the one who has to play a ♣ you just let it ride around to dummy's ♣ K J 10 3.

If East is the one who has to play a ♣ you need to insert the ♣10 or ♣J from dummy.

In either case you will no longer have a ♣ loser.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ Q J 9 ♥ Q 10 7 6 ♦ 10 5 2 ♣ 9 6 4	
♠ 10 6 4 3 2 ♥ K 5 2 ♦ K 8 ♣ K 10 2		♠ A K 8 7 5 ♥ A 4 ♦ A 6 3 ♣ A J 7
	♠ — ♥ J 9 8 3 ♦ Q J 9 7 4 ♣ Q 8 5 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1♠	Pass
3♠	Pass	6♠	
All Pass			

6♠ by East
Lead: ♦Q

West decides a limit raise is better than just jumping to game. East has heard enough and bids the slam.

East is to play 6♠. South leads the ♦Q.

Your first thought is probably that if you can guess the ♣Q you will make all thirteen tricks.

So you win the ♦K and play a ♠ to your ♠K. When South discards a ♦ your second thought is probably that you **MUST** guess the ♣Q just to make twelve tricks.

Hopefully your third thought is that if you use an elimination play you won't have to guess.

Play your ♠A, leaving North with the master ♠Q. Then eliminate ♦s by playing ♦A and ruffing a ♦ in dummy.

Now eliminate ♥s by playing ♥A, ♥K, and ruffing a ♥.

You are ready for the throw-in.

A ♠ to North's ♠Q.

North has just taken the defender's first trick. First and only. Because if he now plays a red card you will ruff in one hand and discard a losing ♣ from the other. And if he plays a ♣ you will no longer have a ♣ loser.

Most elimination plays work on the same principle. The biggest difference is usually the technique you have to use to complete the eliminations.

Here it took two ruffs, one in each hand.

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ 8 3 ♥ K Q 10 8 2 ♦ K 9 5 ♣ K 10 2	
♠ K Q 9 4 2 ♥ 5 ♦ Q 8 2 ♣ 9 6 5 3	N W E S	♠ A 7 6 ♥ 9 7 3 ♦ 10 6 4 3 ♣ Q 8 7
	♠ J 10 5 ♥ A J 6 4 ♦ A J 7 ♣ A J 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
Pass	2♦	Pass	2♥
Pass	3NT	Pass	4♥
All Pass			

4♥ by South
Lead: ♠K

North first transfers you to ♥s, then gives you a choice of which game to play. Knowing you have an 9-card trump fit, you choose 4♥.

South is to play 4♥. The defenders start with ♠K, ♠Q, ♠A.

In addition to the two ♠s already lost you have a potential loser in each minor suit. On the plus side, you have a finesse position in ♦s and a two-way finesse in ♣s. If you work both finesses successfully you make an overtrick - if both fail you will be down 1. Or, you could try for a 100% sure end-play.

Ruff the ♠A with dummy's ♥10 and pull trumps (three rounds).

You cash the ♦K and ♦A.

You eliminate ♦s with the ♦K, ♦A and ♦J. If you are REALLY lucky the ♦Q will fall doubleton, but more than likely a defender will win the third ♦. He won't be happy about it, though.

Whichever defender wins the ♦Q is end-played. If he plays a ♦ or a ♠ you will ruff in one hand and discard a ♣ loser from the other. But if he leads a ♣ instead you no longer have a ♣ loser.

On this Deal an elimination play will guarantee that you make your contract.

However, it also guarantees that you will not make an overtrick.

If you try the two finesses instead you **MIGHT** make an overtrick, but you also might go down 1.

Decide for yourself!

Board 4
East Deals
Both Vul

	♠ Q J 10 5 3 ♥ Q 8 7 2 ♦ 3 ♣ J 8 5	
♠ 8 6 2 ♥ J 3 ♦ J 10 6 5 ♣ 7 6 4 3	N W E S	♠ A ♥ A K 6 ♦ A K Q 9 7 4 ♣ A Q 9
	♠ K 9 7 4 ♥ 10 9 5 4 ♦ 8 2 ♣ K 10 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		2♣	Pass
2♦	Pass	3♦	Pass
4♦	Pass	6♦	
All Pass			

6♦ by West
Lead: ♠Q

You naturally respond 2♦ to East's strong 2♣ opener. Before you know it you are playing a slam - with your mighty 2-point hand! West plays 6♦. North leads the ♠Q.

If the contract appears to depend upon a finesse, try to find another way. Here, you can always try the ♣ finesse, but maybe you can eliminate ♠s and see what happens.

Win the ♠A, play the ♦4 to the ♦10, and ruff a ♠ with the ♦Q. Both opponents followed to the trump.

Play the ♦7 to the ♦J and ruff the last ♠ with the ♦K.

Having eliminated the ♦s and ♠s, now remove the ♥s. Play ♥A, ♥K, and ruff a ♥.

At last it is time to play ♣s.

North plays low.

A ♣ from your hand, playing dummy's ♣9 when North plays low. South will win the trick but will be end-played, forced to either play a ♣ back to dummy's ♣ A Q, or give you a ruff-sluff.

If North puts on either the ♣10 or ♣J you play dummy's ♣Q. If South can win with the ♣K he will once again be end-played, forced to either play a ♣ back to dummy's ♣A 9, or give you a ruff-sluff.

The A Q 9 combination is interesting. Obviously if you have A Q 10 it works very well in an end-play situation.

As you see, A Q 9 actually works just as well.